

1 A JOINT RESOLUTION directing the University of Kentucky, the University of
2 Louisville, and Eastern Kentucky University to coordinate a search for actionable
3 solutions to physician shortages and to explore and expand health care opportunities in
4 medically underserved areas in collaboration with community, state agency, professional
5 associations, and other stakeholders.

6 WHEREAS, over 75 percent of physicians practice in urban areas in Kentucky,
7 leaving many counties with a shortage of physicians; and

8 WHEREAS, the United States Department of Health and Human Services has
9 designated 40 counties as health professional shortage areas for primary care providers;
10 and

11 WHEREAS, without local access to physicians, individuals in medically
12 underserved areas are often compelled to travel long distances to other counties for health
13 care, which may involve transportation and financial barriers and result in individuals
14 going without care; and

15 WHEREAS, regular primary care physician visits serve as the first line in
16 diagnosing illness and have been associated with a reduced number of hospitalizations
17 and emergency room department visits; and

18 WHEREAS, the Association of American Medical Colleges reports that 57 percent
19 of medical residents continued practicing medicine in their training state; and

20 WHEREAS, 38 percent of physicians practice medicine in the same state where
21 they completed undergraduate medical education, and the rate is higher for public
22 undergraduate medical school graduates, 46 percent; and

23 WHEREAS, according to the American Medical Association, the highest state
24 retention rates are for family medicine, 64.6 percent, psychiatry, 64.5 percent, and
25 pediatrics, 60 percent; and

26 WHEREAS, while some efforts have been made to increase medical residency
27 placements and admissions into medical school in Kentucky, these efforts have not been

1 nearly enough to meet the need; and

2 WHEREAS, greater efforts could be taken to encourage medical school graduates
3 to complete their residencies in medically underserved areas so they might be compelled
4 to continue practicing medicine and living there; and

5 WHEREAS, opportunities to expand health care access in medically underserved
6 areas may include health care workforce diversification, innovative technology-enabled
7 solutions and support, and attention to non-clinical health care needs and community-
8 based care;

9 NOW, THEREFORE,

10 ***Be it resolved by the General Assembly of the Commonwealth of Kentucky:***

11 ➔Section 1. (1) The General Assembly directs the University of Kentucky,
12 the University of Louisville, and Eastern Kentucky University to coordinate a search for
13 actionable solutions to the physician shortages and to explore and expand health care
14 opportunities in collaboration with community, state agency, professional associations,
15 and other stakeholders. The search to find actionable solutions and explore opportunities
16 to expand health care access shall focus on the:

17 (a) Shortage of primary and specialty care physicians in medically underserved
18 areas;

19 (b) Chronic lack of access to physician care by medically underserved
20 populations;

21 (c) Retaining of physicians in medically underserved areas; and

22 (d) Workforce, technological, and community-based opportunities to increase
23 access to care.

24 (2) The search and exploration shall include an examination of:

25 (a) Current actions being taken;

26 (b) Possibilities for building on current actions; and

27 (c) Innovative actions that may be taken, including but not limited to:

- 1 1. Sponsorship of community graduate medical education programs;
- 2 2. Growing graduate medical education sites in medically underserved areas;
- 3 3. Encouraging safe international physician recruitment;
- 4 4. Increasing basic administration reimbursement for recruitment and placement
- 5 services of medical students, residents, and physicians;
- 6 5. Integrating workforce diversification in educational programs;
- 7 6. Expanding technological health care delivery options; and
- 8 7. Considering community-based medical models.

9 (3) The search and exploration shall include an analysis of any existing regulatory
10 or statutory barriers to achieving a solution that attracts providers to medically
11 underserved areas and does not limit modifications or expansions to medical education
12 programs.

13 (4) The University of Kentucky, the University of Louisville, and Eastern
14 Kentucky University shall coordinate to develop a report to be submitted to the
15 Legislative Research Commission by January 1, 2027, for referral to the General
16 Assembly. The report shall:

17 (a) Describe and provide data on medically underserved areas and medically
18 underserved populations by county on the:

- 19 1. Shortage of primary and specialty care physicians;
- 20 2. Lack of access to physician care; and
- 21 3. Retention of physicians;

22 (b) Provide an overview of:

- 23 1. Current actions;
- 24 2. Possibilities for building on current actions;
- 25 3. Innovative actions that may be taken; and
- 26 4. Regulatory or statutory barriers; and

27 (c) Provide detailed actional solutions and a discussion of opportunities to expand

1 health care opportunities to address the physician shortages in medically underserved
2 areas of Kentucky, including:

- 3 1. Agencies that may be responsible for the actions;
- 4 2. Resources needed to achieve the actions; and
- 5 3. A suggested timeframe for achieving the solutions.

6 ➔Section 2. (1) The General Assembly finds that Kentucky continues to face
7 a persistent and growing shortage of physicians and other clinicians, resulting in
8 insufficient workforce capacity and impacting access to health care across the state, and
9 strategic action is necessary to expand access to care. Training models at universities
10 across the country and Kentucky have demonstrated that physicians are more likely to
11 remain in or return to the communities in which they trained to establish their practice,
12 specifically in communities where primary academic training activities will occur and
13 will evolve into a collaborative partnership with local and regional public and private
14 higher education institutions and health care providers to deliver education and clinical
15 training.

16 (2) The General Assembly authorizes the University of Kentucky to develop a
17 feasibility study to explore the persistent and growing shortage of physicians and other
18 clinicians in collaboration with all health care workforce partners in and around the
19 Owensboro region to take advantage of HealthForce Kentucky.

20 (3) The feasibility study may be provided to the General Assembly by December
21 1, 2026. Based upon the feasibility study, the General Assembly shall consider funding of
22 up to \$10,000,000 in the 2027 Regular Session to address the findings of the feasibility
23 study.